

2021 A-level Paper 2 : The Impact Of Fashion On The Environment

Suggested Answer Scheme (*Examiners' Comments in italics*)

1. According to the author in lines 1-3, what is the impact of the 'tyranny of fashion'? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
The tyranny of fashion is such that, though our treasured garments may have much life left in them , many are consigned to the dustbin much earlier than they need to be .	The author feels that fast fashion leads to the unnecessary/premature discarding of perfectly good clothes we own.

Examiners' comments: *Weaker responses merely pointed out that clothes were discarded because they quickly went out of fashion but did not mention the wastefulness the author is highlighting. Other weaker responses unnecessarily defined the meaning of 'tyranny', which was in the question, rather than explaining the behaviour it leads to.*

2. From lines 8-9, explain two ways in which the author indicates his disapproval of social media influencers. [2]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
...the curse of the modern era...	The author's use of the word 'curse' suggests that the author sees social media influencers as a blight/bane of society.
...those 'so-called social media influencers'...	The addition of the word 'so-called' suggests that he does not think they deserve to be given such a title. The use of the quotation marks indicates the sarcasm/mockery on the author's part regarding them
(any two of the above for 2 marks)	

Examiners' comments: *Weaker responses were too generalised, saying that the author used powerful language to show disapproval but without focusing on specific words or authorial techniques to back up this claim.*

3. In lines 10-11, the author states that people have more disposable income these days. What further contrasts does the author make between past and present consumer habits in the rest of paragraph 2? Use your own words as far as possible. [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
... less need to make do and mend, as previous generations were obliged to do. It can be cheaper to buy something new than to have it repaired... ...anyway where would we find those sufficiently skilled at sewing and mending? And in today's busy world, do we even have the time to try and find them?	1. Repairing clothes was much more necessary and prevalent in the past compared to now. 2. It is now more costly to have clothes mended and cheaper to just buy a replacement than in the past.

	3. It is harder to find people who are adept/adroit enough to do such work today. 4. Our hectic pace of life today makes it challenging to find the time to locate these people. (1 mark for either Point 1 or 2; 1 mark for Point 3 or 4)
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Examiners' comments: *Weaker responses repeated the idea stated in the question that people today have more money than people in the past. Others did not make sharp enough contrasts between then and now, or described the situation in the past or the present only.*

4. Explain how the author uses language in line 16-17 to convey their strong feelings about the environmental cost of the 'feverish consumption' of fashion. [2]

From the Text	Suggested Explanation
Put starkly...	By adding the phrase 'put starkly', the author is indicating that what he is about to say is something unvarnished and unpalatable.
...every single item we purchase has an adverse effect...	Another way is by using the emphasis that buying even one item will add to the severity of the problem.
The statistics are mind-boggling.	The use of the word 'mind-boggling' suggests that the damage to the environment is almost too great to comprehend/ almost unimaginable.
	(any 2 of the 3 points for 2 marks)

Examiners' comments: *Weaker responses simply said the author used literary techniques such as hyperbole, without giving specific examples, or they paraphrased 'feverish consumption', which was in the question.*

5. In para 5, what does the author suggest is 'amiss', when rivers turn electric yellow or pink?
Use your own words as far as possible. [2]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
	The colours of the rivers described are unnatural/abnormal/alarming [1] and are a result of the toxic colourants leaking from dyeing plants and factories. [1]

Examiners' comments: *Weaker responses only described the colours as 'vivid' or 'bright' but did not suggest they were giving the rivers an abnormal or alarming appearance.*

6. Why does the author use the word 'colossal' (line 39) to describe the cost of polyester to the natural environment? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Explanation
	According to the author, the extent of damage is not only very great but is stupendous/astounding [1] as it affects the whole food chain and ends up with humans consuming polyester fibres. [1]

Examiners' comments: When the author describes the cost of using polyesters 'colossal', he is suggesting a much greater impact than one that is merely 'detrimental', a term used by many candidates. Some candidates offered stronger synonyms such as 'stupendous' or 'astounding', which effectively conveyed the magnitude of the cost.

7. What is ironic about the author's use of the term 'custodians of the planet' in line 44? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
What else can humans, the custodians of the planet, do to damage further the natural environment?	Humans are the supposed guardians of the planet but it is ironic that they are the very ones to harm it instead of protecting it.

Examiners' comments: Weaker responses misunderstood 'custodians', thinking it was to do with being held in custody, causing them to describe humans as 'holding the planet captive'.

8. In paragraph 8, explain how the author supports the claim that there is 'cause for hope' (line 52) and why this claim may not be convincing? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Explanation
Overall use of organic cotton amounts to less than one per cent of the world's annual cotton crop, but there is a growing interest in using it among leading fashion brands ...natural fibres still have to be spun, knitted and woven. Then they have to be dyed, finished and transported – all of which have a detrimental impact on the environment	The increasing use/adoption of organic cotton by major fashion labels is a cause for hope. [1] However, the author added the caveat that the processing and distribution of these more sustainably-grown materials still have damaging effects on the planet. [1]

Examiners' comments: Weaker responses show the fact that this cotton is only used by one percent of manufacturers as a good thing, though it was offered as a very disappointing statistic.

9. Identify two ways in which the final paragraph provides an effective ending to the author's argument [2]

From the Text	Suggested Explanation
	The final paragraph provides an effective ending by reiterating the point he began the passage with regarding the importance of recycling. The final paragraph is effective in emphasizing the urgency of the situation by issuing a call to immediate and speedy action. The use of the pronoun 'we' serves to involve his readers in this campaign/call to action. The final paragraph offers a simple but attention-grabbing/effective solution to the problem of our fast fashion habit. (any 2 of the above points for 2 marks)

10. Using material from paragraphs 9-11 only, (lines 58-61), summarise what the author has to say about how the threat posed to the environment by fast fashion may be addressed.

Write your summary in **no more than 120 words**, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible.**

One way of addressing the threat posed to the environment by fast fashion is ...

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
1. ... circular model of textile production	To adopt a recoverable framework of manufacturing fabric
2. Where materials are re-used wherever possible.	where resources are re-purposed as far as it is feasible.
3. There are charity shops where you can buy others' discarded clothes	There are thrift shops where people can purchase clothes thrown away by others
4. and there are increasing numbers	and there are a rising number
5. Of recycling points in stores	Of recycling stations/counters within the shops' premises.
6. (So far, recycling rates are very low.) A radical change in mindset is needed	A more extreme/drastic/revolutionary change in attitude is called for to raise recycling rates.
7. The need to educate and inform consumers	There is a necessary to teach/provide knowledge to consumers
8. ...to advise on each stage of the process	to guide them on every one/ every single step in the journey/route
9. from buying smart	from making wiser/more informed purchases,
10. to caring for and repairing items	to looking after and mending items,
11. to customisation of items	to more made-to-order purchases,
12. to responsible disposal .	to environmentally-friendly means of throwing items out.

13. Most fashion retailers are ...making the right noises about sustainability	Most fashion businesses are promoting/ advocating eco-friendly fashion.
14. This is only right, as retailers have a moral obligation	This is expected of them ethically/this is their ethical duty
15. to take responsibility for the waste they are creating.	To be accountable for the pollution/
16. The fashion industry should take action at each stage of the supply chain:	The fashion industry should work on every step of the supply chain:
17. begin with sustainable sourcing of fabrics	they should starting with environmentally-friendly ways to obtain textiles,
18. explore possible alternatives to distribution	look for feasible options when bringing products to consumers
19. and recover or recycle clothing.	and reclaim/take back clothing bought.
20. Urge retailers to offer incentives ...to those who recycle their products.	Shop-owners should be persuaded to give benefits to consumers who recycle those items bought from them.
21. Ever more creative thinking is required.	In fact, increasingly more innovative ideas are required
22. Would it be possible to design in such a way	where it is feasible to create products/innovate
23. that we eliminate the need for recycling altogether?	such that the necessity to recycle can be totally removed.

23 possible points

(1-2pts = 1m, 3-4pts = 2m, 5-6pts = 3m, 7-8pts = 4m, 9-10pts = 5m, 11-12pts = 6m, 13-14pts = 7m, 15pts and more = 8m)

Examiners' Comments:

Few summaries exceeded the word limit. Most candidates provided synonyms for key words or phrases in the text. The most common exception was 'recycling points', where candidates were not expected to avoid the use of the precise term 'recycling' but were expected to paraphrase 'points', which many did successfully with an apt noun such as 'stations'. Some did not include a key detail – that these receptacles are inside clothes stores – which differentiated them from the previous point about giving clothes to charity shops. Several responses overlooked the author's point about the need for the fashion industry to source materials that are sustainable.

Stronger responses were thorough and accurate in their selection of the relevant material to include and paraphrase the language in the text with sophisticated synonyms or well-chosen idioms. Stronger responses also featured excellent use of connectives to ensure the summary was fluent and logical.

Weaker responses sometimes included material from outside the designated paragraphs, or paraphrased a whole paragraph without being selective, thereby including irrelevant material. Furthermore, weaker responses often focused unduly on the examples the author gave or the products of recycling, or overlooked the different stages the author suggested, constituting an informed approach to clothing from purchase to disposal.

11. The author makes significant criticisms of today's fashion industry.
How far do you agree or disagree with the author's observations? Illustrate your arguments with examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society? [10]

REQUIREMENTS. Candidates should:

- refer to the author's key ideas and opinions about the major **problems** with today's fashion industry.
- evaluate how bad the situation is with the fashion industry in their own society, including the various stakeholders like the distributors, fashion retailers and fashion consumers.
- support their stand with reasoned arguments and provide examples based on their personal opinion and experience and their observations of the fashion industry in their own society and fashion consumers' habits and behaviours, including their own experience wherever appropriate.

Key Ideas from the text:

1. Fast fashion churns out, seemingly effortlessly, new items every season.
2. The fashion industry is profit-driven and new and frequent collections are promoted by models and social media influencers.
3. People have higher disposable incomes and they do not mend clothes items as it is cheaper to buy new ones or it is too time-consuming or difficult to find tailors skilled in doing repairs or alteration.
4. Garments are discarded when they are still in good condition, resulting in much wastage.
5. These garments end up in landfills or are incinerated, having a significant carbon footprint.
6. The fashion industry contributes significantly to waste water production and carbon emissions as well as pollution of rivers from chemicals used in dyeing of fabric.
7. Pesticides used in growing cotton can be hazardous to human health, especially the young, and also contributes to the development of 'superweeds' which in turn requires more toxic chemicals to fight against.
8. Polyester, commonly used in fashion, sheds microfibres when washed and this contributes to plastic pollution in oceans and they find their way back into the food we eat.
9. Sometimes, the fashion industry destroys its own stock to guard against counterfeits or protect the brand's exclusivity.

Some strategies for evaluation to show nuance and possible examples

1. Identify **trends/developments** that exacerbate the problem of fast fashion in Singapore. Examples can be the rise of online shopping platforms and fashion websites that make fashion shopping cheaply accessible, convenient and enticing with the attractive models in alluring photos of the latest fashion trends. Examples include Shein that sell clothes that cost as little as \$10 for a trendy outfit or online platforms like Shopee and Lazada which carry countless fashion labels.

Some recent **trends** can also have a mitigating effect on the harm of fashion. For example 'thrifting' is more popular now, with people, especially the young, open to the idea of buying and wearing 'pre-loved' items and the proliferation of such shops such as Refash, The Fashion Pulpit and Threadlightly allow more people to swap, sell or buy clothes instead of having them end up discarded. Slow fashion brands are emerging in Singapore, such as Paradigm Shift Label and Soon Lee, which release new collections over a longer period and take preorders for clothes, reducing wastage from over-manufacturing.

It is also worth noting that the **attitudes and perceptions** towards fast fashion may be changing due to increased awareness, where many of the younger generation are conscious of the detrimental impacts of fast fashion. It is increasingly common to see them expressing the ills of fast fashion online through videos and infographics on pages like SG Climate Rally on Instagram. Analysing trends allows for a discussion of **change over time** – is the problem of fashion getting worse due to rising affluence and social media influencers flaunting their latest fashion acquisitions or has it become less problematic as people are more well-informed and more ‘woke’ about the problems associated with fast fashion?

According to a report by Channel News Asia, the secondhand fashion space has seen an unprecedented rise with the market expected to grow by more than 10 times faster than traditional retail by 2025. This can largely be attributed to changing consumer behaviours, environmental concerns and the digitalisation of alternatives to fast fashion. Additionally, it is possible to explore the role of the Covid-19 pandemic and the rise of Work From Home (WFH) in reducing the need for fast fashion and obtaining many new outfits.

2. Identify the different **profiles** of fashion consumers. Are the younger generation, for example teenagers and young working adults, more likely to spend on fast fashion? Are female consumers more susceptible to buying more clothes than their male counterparts? Are the older generation, especially those who lived through the war or experienced poverty in Singapore’s early years of independence, more likely to be frugal, buy less and repair more? Students can use examples of themselves/their peers/siblings and compare their fashion consumer behaviour with that of their parents’ or grandparents’.
3. Consider the **priorities and concerns** of Singaporeans. Is convenience, accessibility and cost of fast fashion more important to individuals than being concerned about its harms? Multiple shopping malls in Singapore feature many fast fashion brands and labels such as H&M, Cotton On, Forever 21 and ZARA and these stores often have massive seasonal sales that attract large throngs of customers. Despite the rising affluence in Singapore, are many really willing to invest in more sustainable fashion that is often significantly pricier? What **realities** of the Singapore context might explain this tendency?
4. Consider any **unique cultural aspects** of Singaporean society that could affect the way we consume fashion. For example, festive occasions like Chinese New Year involve traditional beliefs that new clothes must be bought and worn for the new year. There exists a stigma around secondhand clothes for such occasions. Chinese New Year often includes buying new outfits every year and discarding old ones and this could significantly lead to the preference for fast fashion sources like Shein and ZARA for their affordable and trendy options. Clothes designs that are specific to seasons (e.g. cheongsam dresses for Chinese New Year) are not frequently worn day-to-day too. These tie in with what the author discussed about the habit of disposing of clothes that are still in good condition or under-utilising them.
5. Identify any contradictions in **expectation vs. reality**. Do Singaporeans claim to be concerned about sustainability on social media or public platforms but still subscribe to a hyper-consumerist lifestyle of excessive and needless consumption? A study by globescan recently discovered that while 44% of respondents desired to lead a more sustainable lifestyle, only 23% have actually undertaken major lifestyle changes to achieve this. This is because it takes a lot of commitment and discipline to change old habits and consumers are frequently faced with temptations (discounts, promotions) to spend further.

Consider the role of firms in perpetuating this issue (consistent sales like Black Friday, 10.10, 11.11 and now every other number like 5.5 and 6.6 etc on platforms like Shopee and Lazada. Why might this contradiction exist? Do individuals and firms pledge allegiance to the sustainable cause for the sake of **image, reputation and maybe even clout**?

Examiners' Comments

The topic of fashion and the problems associated with fast fashion clearly attracted the interest of all candidates. They engaged well with the topic, giving many vigorous and wide-ranging responses: the strongest often covering their own experience, that of their peers, their parents, and grandparents, and their society. Many weaker responses were too brief or incomplete, or too descriptive of a situation and lacked evaluation.

Many candidates gave a vigorous defence of Singapore's recycling programme, point out that the Asian way was to be frugal and pragmatic: this way of living has been inculcated by their grandparents, and encouraged or reinforced by lessons at school, so that clothes past their best are handed down to the next generation or utilised as pieces of cloth for cleaning. These candidates were quick to dismiss the environmental impact of fast fashion in Singapore as being minimal, pointing out that clothes in question are manufactured in other countries and then imported, thus clearing Singapore of any responsibility for the damage caused by their production and later disposal. These responses often reject the idea that the author puts forward that stores launch new collections for each new season, by saying that Singapore essentially has only one season – 'perpetual summer' as one described it – and most people buy light casual wear to feel comfortable rather than be tied to such promotional campaigns.

While some defended the regular purchasing of new styles as 'expressing one's identity and status', others took a very different view, seeing Singaporeans as having 'an inexorable need to be on trend', which led to them being 'keen to jump on the latest fashion bandwagons'. This interpretation presented Singaporeans as 'a materialistic populace that over-prioritise material goods' and responsible for the disposal of perfectly good items into Singapore's landfill, which is estimated to be full by 2030. The fact that this site is not on the mainland meant citizens were barely aware of its existence as it was 'out of sight and out of mind'.